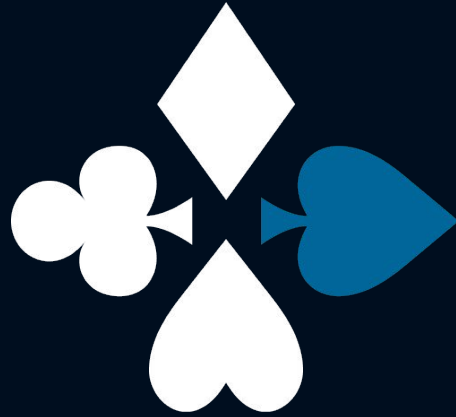




Pokerbots 2026 Final Event

6.9630 Co-Presidents: Sri Saraf and Bobby Costin

Meet the team



Sri Saraf
Co-President



Bobby Costin
Co-President



Sejal Rathi
Vice President

Meet the team



Jacob David
Head of Curriculum



Jacob Jobraeel
Innovation Chair

Meet the team



Paco Gomez-Paz
ML Lead

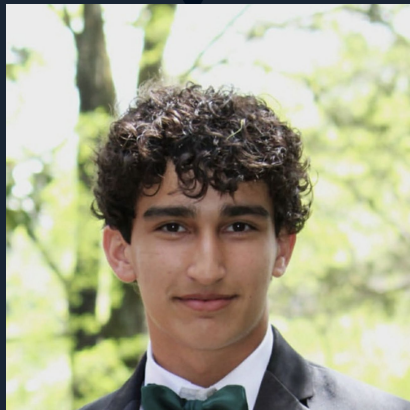


Steve Zhang
Server Lead



Sam Zhou
Tech Lead

Meet the team



Landon Sims
Engine Developer



Reese Long
Server Developer



Alan Duan
Treasurer



Michelle Gao
Sponsorship Director

Sponsors



CITADEL | CITADEL Securities



2026 Variant

Engine Developer: Landon Sims

2026 Variant - Toss or Hold'em

Both players are dealt three hole cards instead of two:

- The flop is then two cards which can be seen by both players
- The players sequentially toss one of their cards into the board
- The board then contains 4 cards, followed by a turn (5 cards) and a river (6 cards)
- Best 5-card hand wins

GOAL:

Take advantage of your toss choice while trying to deduce your opponent's info!



What is Pokerbots?

Head Instructor: Bobby Costin

Competition

- Compete with 80 teams for \$50k+ in prizes
- 150+ student users on the scrimmage server across undergrad and grad years
- 6 tournaments throughout the month
- Total tournament hands of Toss or Hold'em: 600,000,000+

Class

- Lectures and Recitation/Office Hours
- Two guest talks: GTO Wizard and Noam Brown
- Poker Social event
- Two Hackathons to mingle and grind

Lecture Series

- Topics in statistics, game theory, machine learning
- Coding Demos
- Free Lunch!
- Giveaway Games!





Variant Analysis

ML Lead: Paco Gomez-Paz

Structure of Winning Pokerbots

- Two Approaches:
 - Leveraged ML methods (e.g., CFR and AlphaHoldEm)
 - Built handcrafted strategies grounded in human poker intuition.
- Used scrimmage logs to gather feedback and improve their strategy.

Variant Trends

- Nutted hands (Flushes/Straights/Full Houses) more common
- Discarded phase narrows players ranges significantly
- Being In Position becomes more valuable (discard second)

Exploitative Play

- Infer opponent playstyle over game history with hand crafted features
- Use unconventional bet sizes to push opponents into unfamiliar spots.
- Sacrifice EV to reduce variance against weaker bots

Resource Management

- Understand that the objective is to obtain enough chips to check/fold
- Winning bots check folded the last ~100 hands
- Use Binomial distribution to simulate auto-folding outcomes

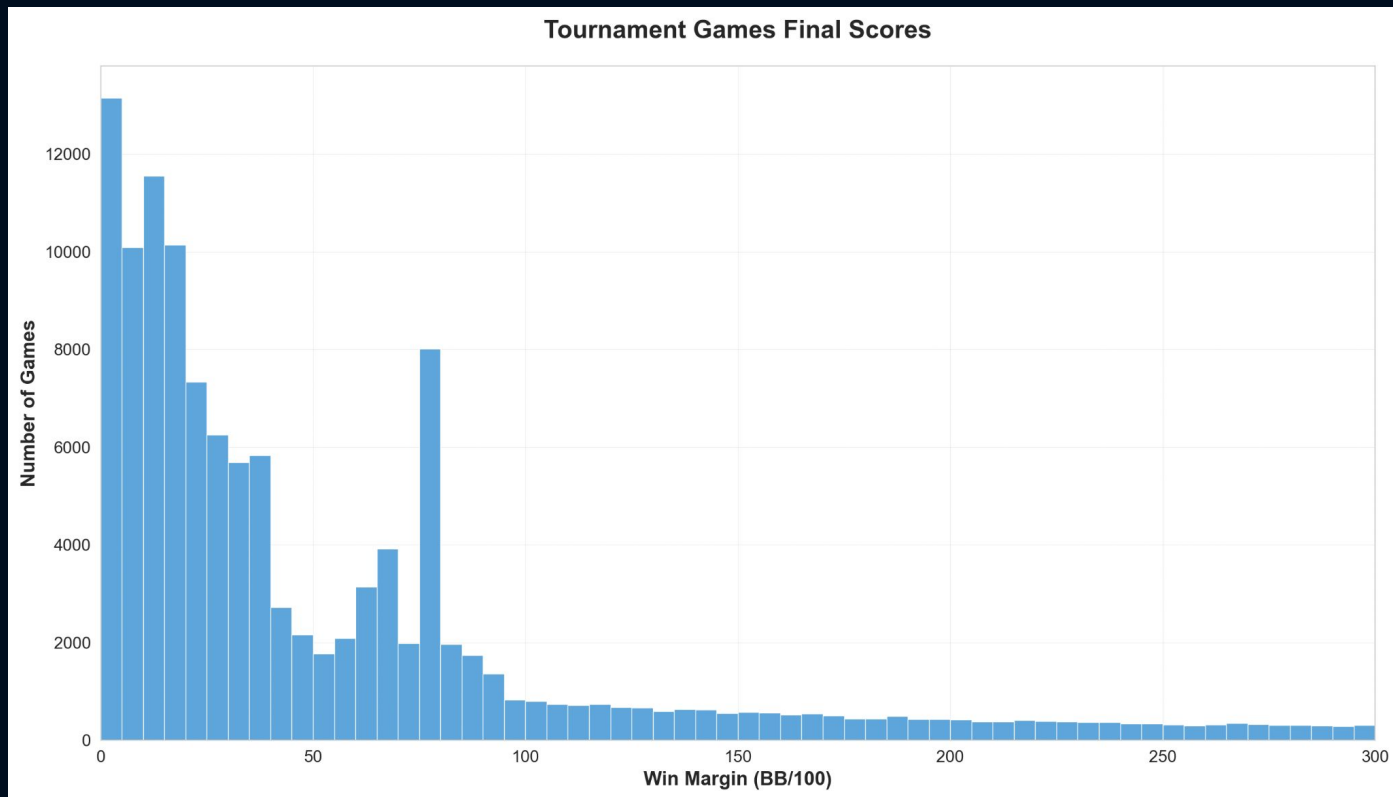
What Good Teams Did Well

- ML-based Techniques
 - Focused heavily on performance optimization
 - Used variance-reduction methods to speed up convergence
 - Extended bucketing/abstraction methods to handle the discard phase.
- Hand-crafted Strategies
 - Designed intuition driven features to model opponents playstyle
 - Used Monte Carlo simulation to guide action selection
 - Analyzed logs to identify leaks in opposing players strategies

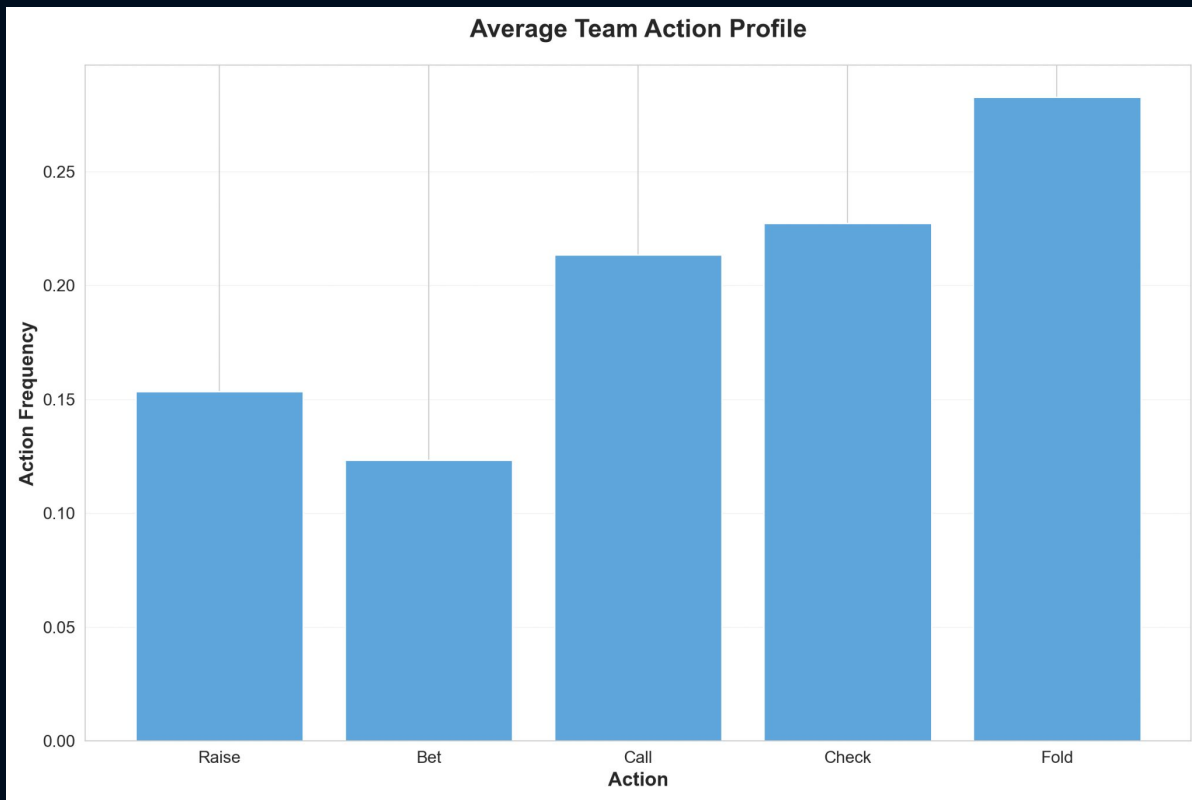
Final Tournament Analysis

Vice President: Sejal Rathi

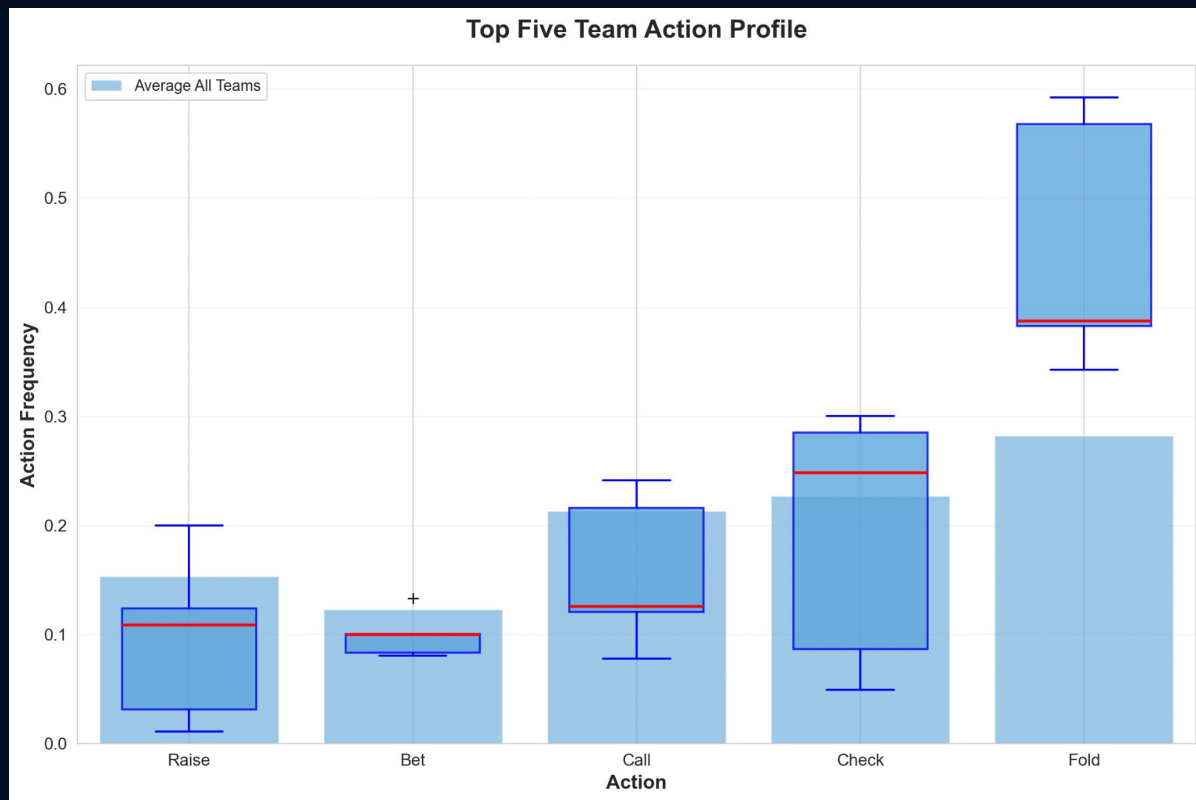
Games were not all decisive



Most teams play tight-aggressive...



...but top teams play more tight-aggressive



Competitor and Tournament Stats

Server Developer: Reese Long

Competitor Stats

78 non-reference teams

2571 bots submitted

31,970,000+ challenge hands played

Tournament Stats

3 Weekly Tournaments +

2 Lightning Tournaments +

1 Final Tournament!

619,885 Tournament Games played!

Platinum & Gold Sponsor Awards

Sponsorship Director: Michelle Gao



BEST USE OF AI



BEST USE OF AI

Beta Punters



hudson river trading
FORECASTING AWARD



hudson river trading

FORECASTING AWARD

redacted

Balyasny



BEST DISCARDER

Balyasny



BEST DISCARDER

double crossers



CITADEL | CITADEL Securities

MOST IMPROVED



CITADEL | CITADEL Securities

MOST IMPROVED
martingale

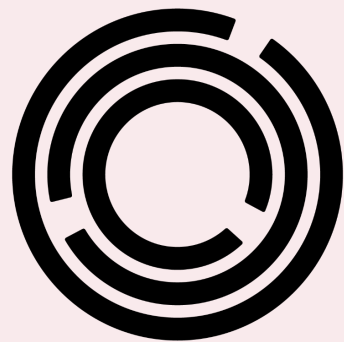


HIGHEST SORTINO RATIO

DRII 

HIGHEST SORTINO RATIO

spongebot



**Jane
Street®**

THE LIQUIDITY PROVIDER



THE LIQUIDITY PROVIDER

Suits GPT



sphinx

SPHINX JOKER PRIZE



sphinx

SPHINX JOKER PRIZE

**Dad, what happened to my
college fund?**



SUSQUEHANNA

HIGHEST SHARPE RATIO



SUSQUEHANNA

HIGHEST SHARPE RATIO

double crossers



Pokerbots Special Prizes

Co-president: Sri Saraf

Best Attendance

Mingjia Zhang (\$200)

Azjargal Ganbold (\$100)

Ceylan Ceylan, Christopher Chan, Landon Hering,
Paulius Karvelis, Victoria Fang (\$50 each)

Most active on Piazza (\$50 each)

Matan Yablon

Victoria Fang

Sanjith Udupa

Biggest Upset (\$500)

don't panic

David Zhang

won single matchup with
954 ELO difference!

Third place in language (\$125 each)

Python:

martingale

Anna Thomas

C++:

bardly knower

Lee Chen

Second place in language (\$250 each)

Python:

47Ronin

Alain Irakarama

Matthew Zho

C++:

fold me daddy

Kyle Zhang

Alexander Skula

First place in language (\$500 each)

Python:

**Policy Gradient
Is All You Need**

Zhiyuan Fan

Java:

prw

Sanjith Udupa
Aaron Hu

C++:

**Chasers 1/2
Regs**

Thomas Liu
Ruiyang Luo
Vishal Nandakumar

Most Time at Top of Scrimmage Server (\$1000)

Most Time at Top of Scrimmage Server (\$1000)

Policy Gradient Is All You Need

Zhiyuan Fan

Grand Prize Winners

Co-Presidents: Sri and Bobby

Best Freshman-Majority Team (\$2000)

Best Freshman-Majority Team (\$2000)

martingale

Anna Thomas

Time for the top 5 teams!

The slide features a solid blue background. On the left side, there are several overlapping circles of varying shades of blue, creating a decorative, abstract pattern. The text "Fifth place (\$1000)" is written in a white, sans-serif font, positioned in the upper left quadrant of the slide.

Fifth place (\$1000)

Fifth place (\$1000)

last brain cell

Miranda Wang



Fourth place (\$2000)

Fourth place (\$2000)

horseshoes

Jordan Lefkowitz, Elliott Liu

Third place (\$3,500)

Third place (\$3,500)

Fruit Ninja

Eddie Wei, Ivy Zheng, Ekeoma Osondu

Second place (\$6,500)

Second place (\$6,500)

double crossers

Christopher Chan, Landon Hering

Just for fun...



Just for fun...

Best Strategy Report (\$50.00): Statistical_Beaver

Most Number of Bots submitted (\$55.55): 6 7 suited (555 bots!)

Best Team Name (\$25.00): Get Even or Get Even Worse

First place (\$10,000)

First place (\$10,000)

hey0999

David Zhang, Ben Chen, Evan Kim, Rich Wang

Random Raffle Time!



Airpods Pro 4

Winner:
nbhakar





Puzzle Contest Prizes

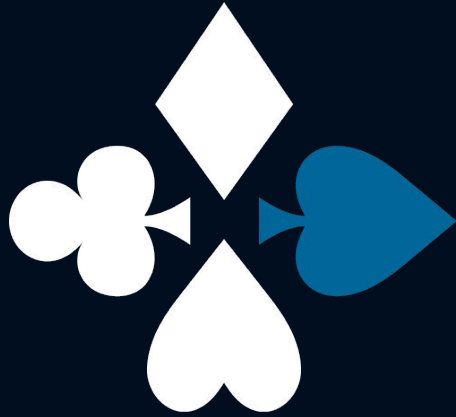
LG Curved 32" Monitor

Winner:
mjz (94 chips)



Poker Tournament!

- Tentative date is 2/21 in the BC Porter Room
- Food 🤪🤪
- Cash prizes!



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